the BJP has honoured these demands by setting up the boards."

There has been no survey to suggest the population of specific groups within OBCs. So, political parties draw up "rough estimates" about each community's strength in a constituency on the basis of names in the voter lists, says advocate Rameshwar Singh, who represents various OBC groups in the MP High Court. The three biggest groups, as per these estimates, are Yadavs, Lodhis and Kurmis. But that is not stopping parties from reaching out to the smaller groups. "Even the Congress has decided to give tickets to smaller OBC groups to secure their representation in the Vidhan Sabha," claims Singh.

THE BJP REGIME IN MP IS SETTING UP WELFARE BOARDS TO WOO SMALLER GROUPS WITHIN OBCs/SCs, LIKE THE CONGRESS GOVT DID IN CHHATTISGARH TWO YEARS AGO

The setting up of the Rajak Kalyan Board in particular is expected to placate MP's washermen community, which has been seeking SC status. But it's not as if the BJP has suddenly woken up to these OBC groups and their aspirations. Chouhan, who is into his fourth term as the CM, would hold community-specific meetings of panchayats at his residence as early as in his second term (2008-13). Even ahead of the announcement to set up the four OBC boards, he attended a Vishwakarma meeting in March and addressed the Sahu community on April 2.

But will this populist move convert into votes? "In my experience, such election-year sops do little for the ruling party," says senior journalist and political commentator Rashid Kidwai. "It's the government's proven track record on welfare that translates into the beneficiary community's votes." The constitution of the boards, says Kidwai, begs another question. Why did it take the ruling BJP 18 years for this step? ■



A FATAL QUEST
The Chaudhary family

had already been convicted in New Jersey in 2019 for smuggling foreign nationals into the US. But after serving a year's sentence, Bhavin resumed his racket from Gujarat. Also, agencies are yet to bring the three accused in the Dingucha case—Rajinder Pal Singh, Fenil Patel and Bitta Singh alias Bittu Paji—to India.

The state administration is naturally under pressure, and thus, multiple agencies—Gandhinagar, Mehsana and Ahmedabad local police, the Directorate of Crime Branch and the Anti-Human Trafficking Unit of the CID—have been working in tandem to curb this multi-nation, deep-rooted nexus.

Such incidents also bring to light the dangerous routes families are willing to take in order to reach the US. The most common method is flying from India to Canada on a student or visitor visa, and then crossing over illegally into the US. But such student visas may not always be legitimate: a related scam, of fake IELTS scores and interviews, was uncovered last year when four youths, who were rescued from the St Regis river while attempting to enter the US, could not converse in basic English when produced in a US court. All four had student visas. Investigation in the IELTS scam is ongoing.

Others take even more dangerous routes—travelling to Mexico via Turkey, and then entering the US. In December last year, a man identified as Brijkumar Yadav from Gandhinagar's Kalol taluka fell from the Trump wall and died, while his family fell on the US side and suffered serious injuries. Another route takes people to Uganda and Kenya, where they work legally for a few years and then move to Mexico to cross over into the US. Conversations with those who managed to reach the US in the past have revealed that people usually understood that what they were doing was a risky undertaking, even though they did not know the exact nature of the challenges during the journey.

What drives them despite everything is the search for a better future: a majority of those from north Gujarat who enter the US illegally are farmers with land holdings that have shrunk over the years due to divisions within the family. In Dingucha village, for instance, which has a population of about 3,000, over 1,800 people have migrated to the US or Canada over the past few years. The great American dream remains a potent lure for families and individuals in Gujarat, but some end up paying for it with death. ■